

Vote-Selling and Vote-Buying: Does the House Always Win? Gambling Votes in the Lab

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Today we're Going to Talk about Sequencing

- Sequencing creates losers and winners depending on **who plays first**.
- ✓ My talk will be about **sequencing in clientelism**.
- Does moving first help parties buy cheaper, or help voters sell higher?

Same exchange, different first mover



Who moves first changes
who captures the surplus.

Clientelism: distribution of private rewards to individuals during political elections in exchange for electoral support (Nichter, 2014).



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E.g., cash for your vote.



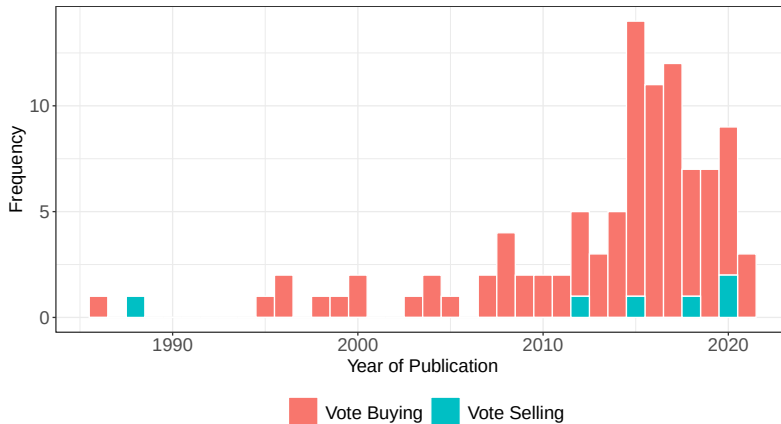
Sequencing and Clientelism: Supply and Demand

- **Qualitative:** how **voters begin** the sequence, and **sell their votes** ([vote selling](#)).
- **Quantitative:** how **parties begin** the sequence, and **buy votes** ([vote buying](#)).

Sequencing and Clientelism: Supply and Demand

- **Qualitative:** how **voters begin** the sequence, and **sell their votes** (*vote selling*).
- **Quantitative:** how **parties begin** the sequence, and **buy votes** (*vote buying*).
- ✓ **We argue:** clientelism is a **market**, with both *buyers and sellers*.
- ✓ **The gap:** the literature has failed to consider the political economy of both vote-buyers *and* vote-sellers.

Sequencing and Clientelism: Supply and Demand



Annual frequency of Web of Science publications whose abstracts include the terms “vote buying” and “vote selling.”

Our Paper and Today's Talk

- Exactly what we tackle: integrate **vote buying** *and* **vote selling** into the same framework.

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- Theory: formalize a **spatial model** with one voter and two parties.
 1. **Parties move first.**
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- Experiment: we designed a lab experiment based on the spatial model.
- Findings:
 - ✓ **When parties move first:** transfers concentrate on **party supporters**.
 - ✓ **When voters move first:** they **demand higher prices** from winning parties that are ideologically far away.
 - ✓ Voters **make more** when parties begin the exchange.

A Prospect-Theoretic Spatial Theory of Vote Buying

- In our design, parties value buying votes because it might reduce electoral loss.

$$R_i = q(v_i, P_d)W_i$$

expected

stake



R_i

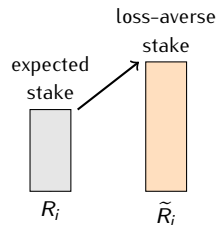
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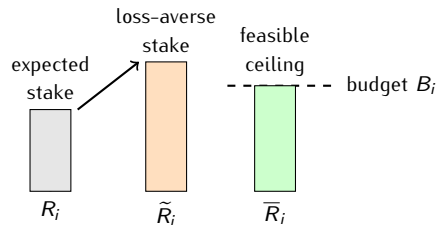
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Core idea

Loss aversion makes electoral stakes, R_i , look larger ($\tilde{R}_i$).

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Successful buying requires $c_i(s_{-i}) \leq \bar{R}_i$, and c_i rises with ideological distance.

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[H3] Higher Voter Payoffs Under Party Initiative

- When parties initiate vote buying, voters can earn more because loss-averse parties may pay an insurance premium above the minimum switching price.

$s_i = c_i(s_{-i}) + \rho_i$, with ρ_i increasing in λ_i , ℓ_i , and R_i .

Laboratory Implementation

- **Participants and implementation**
 - Following the formal model, we designed a lab experiment in oTree.
 - Recruited 102 adult participants.
 - Payed them according to the quality of their decisions.

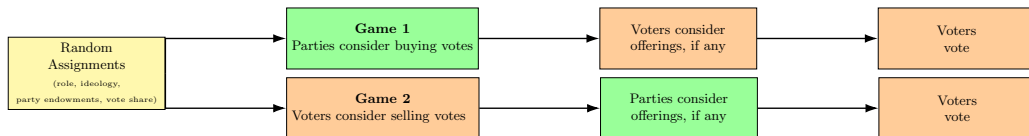
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 - Each participant played the game **three times** (n=306).
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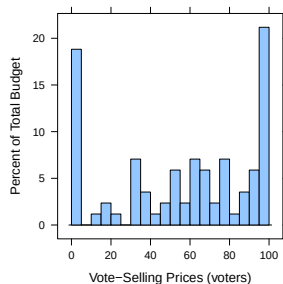
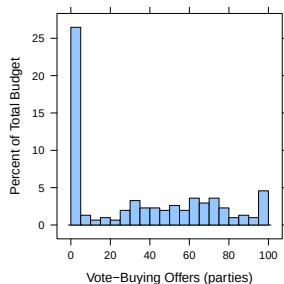
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- **What was randomized (3x)**
 - Role (party, voter).
 - Voter's ideology (payoffs if A or B wins).
 - Party budgets (to buy votes).
 - Vote shares.

Randomized Sequencing in Two Games



The Dependent Variable: Vote-buying and vote-selling prices



- The two histograms describe **very different worlds**:
 - When **parties** move first.
 - When **voters** move first.
- What explains the differences of these two games?

Modeling when Parties Begin

- What explains the variance of the vote-buying offers? Estimate OLS:

$$\text{Offer}_{di} = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \text{Ideology}_{di} + \gamma_2 \text{VoteShare}_{di} + \gamma_3 \text{Pivotal}_d + u_{di}$$

- Also fit a logit model for the probability of making *any* offer (same covariates).
- Standard errors clustered at the party level.

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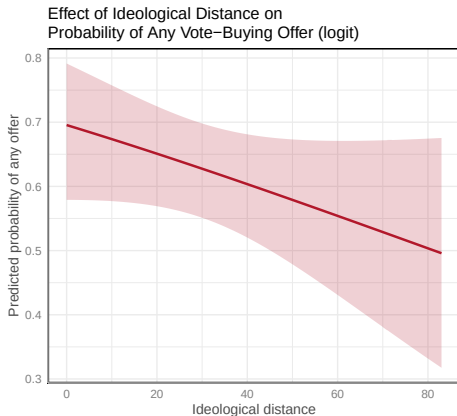
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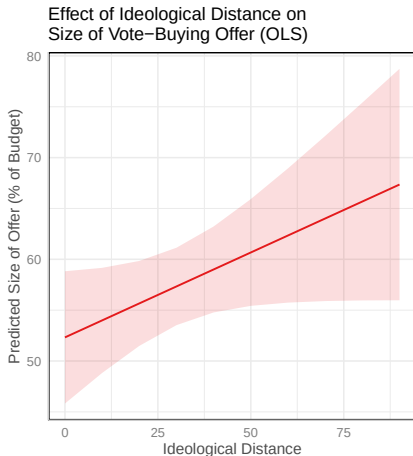
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Results: Vote-Buying Offers and Core Targeting



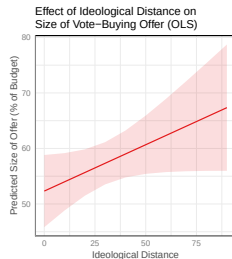
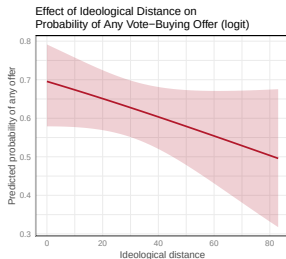
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- As ideological distance increases, parties are **less likely** to make any offer at all.
- If they offer, parties pay **more** to more distant voters.
- So: parties target followers cheaply (left), but pay more to buy distant voters (right).

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- Dependent variable: requested price as % of party budget,

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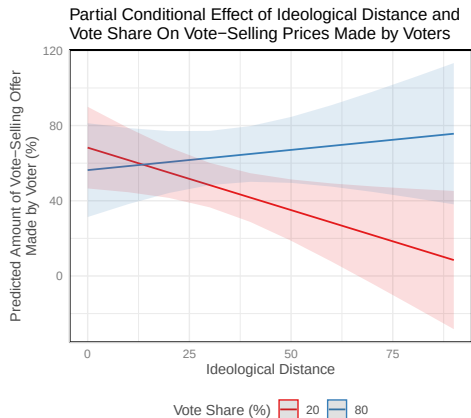
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Requested Prices by Ideology and Electoral Strength



- For electorally **weak parties**, distance lowers requested prices.
- For electorally **strong parties**, distance raises requested prices: voters demand compensation for switching sides.

Sequencing and Payoffs by Game



- Party payoffs are similar across both games.
- Voters earn more when parties initiate the exchange.

Interpretation

Vote buying lets voters capture more surplus (due to party's loss aversion); **vote selling** generates high demands, but also more rejection.

Main Takeaways

- **Conceptual move:** integrated **vote buying** and **vote selling** into the same framework.
- **Theory:** formalized a spatial model with one voter and two parties.
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- **Experiment:** based on the formal model, we designed an econ lab experiment.
- **Findings:**
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Thank you



- Paper and abstract: www.HectorBahamonde.com
- Feedback very welcome.